



Effective Prompting

What's really happening when you hit send

Example formatting only — lesson content abridged for demonstration purposes.

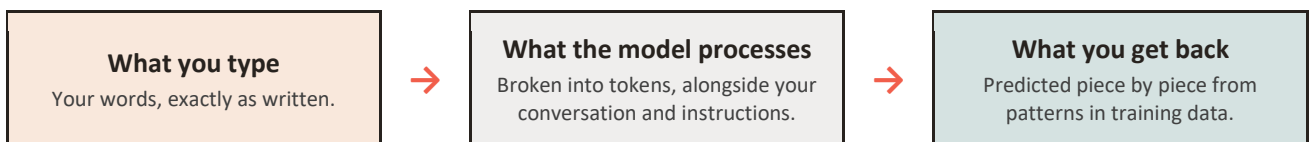
When you send a message to an AI tool, you are not talking to something that understands the way a person does. This unit looks at what actually happens between the words you type and the words you get back, and how understanding that gap makes your prompts noticeably more effective.

What you'll be able to do

- Explain, in plain terms, the difference between what you type and what the model processes.
- Rewrite a vague prompt into one that gets a more specific, more useful response.
- Recognise the most common reason a prompt gets a disappointing answer.

What you type vs. what the model does

The three stages below happen every time you send a prompt, whether or not you can see them:



NOTE

Every reply is generated fresh from your visible conversation. There is no memory between separate chats unless a tool is deliberately added to provide one.



TRY THIS

Take a prompt you have used recently and add who the answer is for, how long it should be, and what tone it should have. Notice how much more specific the response gets.

Turning a vague prompt into an effective one

A prompt works better when it tells the model who the answer is for, how long it should be, and what it should sound like. Compare:

Vague prompt

Effective prompt



<i>Write something about dogs.</i>	Write a 150-word, beginner-friendly paragraph explaining why dogs make good first pets, in a warm and encouraging tone.
<i>Fix this email.</i>	Rewrite this email to sound more polite and professional, in under 100 words: [paste email]



WARNING

Common mistake

Assuming the model remembers earlier conversations, or knows what you meant rather than what you actually typed. If it is not in the prompt or the visible context, the model does not have it.



Reflect

Before your next AI conversation, notice: did your prompt say who the answer is for and how it should be shaped? If not, that's usually the fastest fix.